



This ornamental brick from China's Eastern Han period shows a procession that includes horse-drawn carriages.

JESUS CHRIST (c. 4 BCE–33 CE)

Jesus, a carpenter from Nazareth, began his ministry in his early 30s. He taught in the Jewish tradition, calling for the reform of the Temple and for the love of one's neighbour to take precedence over the strict observance of religious law. Jesus gathered a group of twelve disciples around him, but was targeted by Jewish conservatives afraid of his growing influence. In 33, the Roman authorities in Judaea executed Jesus by crucifixion, but the disciples, convinced that Jesus had risen from the dead, continued his teaching.



under his predecessors, and reinstated Luoyang as the capital. He faced renewed tension with the **Hsiung-nu** on China's northern frontier, but failed to take advantage of their split into two **rival chiefdoms** in 49.

The **Roman Empire** once again faced an **unclear succession** at the death of Tiberius in 37. He had named two heirs, but Gemellus was soon pushed aside because Gaius, nicknamed **Caligula** ("little boots"), was popular with the senate and the army. Caligula's behavior as emperor became increasingly erratic—he had Gemellus executed, and had many of Tiberius's supporters killed. He also had his sister's husband—his heir apparent—condemned to death. After visiting the Rhineland

legions in 39, Caligula marched them to the coast opposite Britain to launch an invasion; when they got there, he merely had them collect seashells along the beach.

Independent **Jewish kingdoms** in Palestine **collapsed** as Roman power grew, creating a powerful ferment of religious change.

John the Baptist preached in the 20s, followed in around 30 by a new preacher, **Jesus**. After Jesus's death in 33, his disciples began to spread his message more widely. By around 50, communities of Christians, as Jesus's followers were known, would be established throughout Western Asia, with particularly large groups in Antioch and the first appearance of **Christians in Rome**.

IN INDIA, GROUPS OF YUEZHI NOMADS occupying land in Bactria united under Kujula Kadphises (30–80), who founded the **Kushan Empire** and conquered parts of Gandhara. Although few details of Kujula's reign are known, he **minted coins** in imitation of both Greek and Roman models, demonstrating that Bactria and northwestern India remained very much a **cultural crossroads**.

In northwestern Europe, a group of disgruntled officers of Rome's Praetorian Guard **assassinated Caligula** in January 41, tired of his cruel and irrational behavior (see 24–40). In 43, the new emperor, **Claudius** (r. 41–54), sent an invasion force of four legions led by **Aulus Plautius**, governor of Pannonia, to **conquer Britain**. The Romans landed unopposed at Richborough, pushed on to London, and then captured



Christian catacomb, Rome

At first, *Roman Christians* did not have their own cemeteries. Later, they buried their dead in underground complexes called *catacombs*.

Colchester, the capital of the principal British resistance leader, **Caractacus**. Claudius himself made a brief appearance at the fall of Colchester, before returning to Rome to bask in the glory of having **acquired a new province**. In 47, the Romans paused briefly in their conquest of Britain, having reached a line roughly between the Humber River in the east and the Severn River in the west. They began **establishing legionary fortresses** in their new province, including at Exeter and Lincoln. Aulus Plautius's replacement, **Ostorius Scapula** invaded Wales, where Caractacus was continuing the resistance. In 50, he defeated an army of Silurian and Ordovician tribesmen, and Caractacus fled to the imagined safety of the Brigantes tribe in northern England. However, the Brigantian queen, **Cartimandua**, handed Caractacus over to the Romans, and Roman Britain remained relatively trouble free during the following decade.

The 40s saw a struggle in the early **Christian community** between those who wanted to remain within the Jewish tradition and those, led by **Paul**, who favored the inclusion of gentiles (non-Jews) in the Christian church. Paul began a series of **missionary journeys** in 46 which led him through Anatolia and Greece to Rome, where he was **martyred** around 62. A charismatic preacher, Paul also wrote a powerful series of **epistles** (letters) to various fledgling Christian groups. In appealing to a wider group than



EMPEROR CLAUDIUS
(10 BCE–54 CE)

Caligula's uncle, Claudius, was an unlikely candidate for Roman emperor. However, he turned out to be intelligent and forceful, putting down two revolts in 42, after which he executed more than 300 senators. He was unfortunate in his choice of wives: he had his wife Messalina executed after she had an affair, and her successor Agrippina (Caligula's sister) is reputed to have poisoned him.

the Jews within the Roman empire, Paul ensured that **Christianity spread** sufficiently to help it weather the storms of **persecution** that began under the Emperor Nero in 64. By the late 4th century, Christianity would be the **majority religion** within the Roman Empire.

